

Chapter 90_2 - Searching for Her

After Divine Venerable Chu Ling perished together with the demon clans and Penglai emerged from the mountains to aid the four realms¹, the four realms finally ended a year of warfare and chaos, returning to peace and prosperity throughout the land.

The six major sects and four great families of the Immortal Realm also flourished, with talented individuals emerging in large numbers. As the leader of the four realms, Penglai repeatedly protected the world, and mortal beings called them gods. Countless temples rose from the ground with abundant incense offerings.

The troublemaking demon clans were forced back to the Demon Realm and no longer dared to show themselves. The demons and monsters in the world were also completely slaughtered. That world-destroying person, Ning Fuyi, had also disappeared without a trace. Some said she hid her identity out of fear of Penglai, while others said she had long been killed by Penglai's immortal soldiers in the Demon Realm.

However, not all demons and monsters disappeared. A few years later, a mysterious force emerged in the martial world. These people were either demons or monsters, but they never burned, killed, or plundered, nor did they bully the weak.

Their only mischief was frightening people. It was said they loved to reveal their demonic forms to scare children, and when the children cried, they would take their tears and then flee.

People from the immortal sects and Penglai had tried to eliminate these people, but they all had extraordinary skills, coming like shadows and going like wind, with various protective talismans for saving their lives. Thus they ran rampant for years without ever being caught.

As they appeared repeatedly, they gained some reputation in the martial world. People speculated that behind this force was a demon lord who specialized in consuming human fear.

As the legends grew, this demon lord gained a name: the Extremely Ugly Blue-Faced Fanged Monster, and the force under its command was called the Terror Hall².

The demons and monsters of Terror Hall grew more numerous each year and became more brazen. Penglai and the various immortal sects couldn't catch them, angrily holding demon-slaying conferences repeatedly to discuss how to eliminate them completely. However, these demon-slaying conferences were held year after year, and eventually the demon-slaying conference became another grand gathering following the Zhaoyao Conference³. Yet not a single demon or monster was caught.

And so, thirty years passed.

Thirty years was but a finger snap for the immortal sects, but even though the time wasn't long, it was enough to bury many past events.

A crow with glossy feathers flew over the ink-wash mountains with their alternating light and shadow, braving strong winds to return to the great desert. It entered the Demon Realm through the sandstorm, and the few demons and monsters wandering by the roadside, upon seeing it, all covered their faces and hid deeper in the Demon Realm.

The crow flew to the entrance of the demon cave and stopped. The huge archway was hung with dried heads—some had become dry bones, others still emanated waves of demonic energy.

These were all the demon clans who had come to challenge over the past thirty years, now all turned to skulls.

The crow cawed twice, then transformed into human form and landed, walking through the gate with head held high and chest out.

"Left Envoy, sir." The little demons guarding the gate put away their two demonic halberds and fawned over her.

"Mm." She walked with her head raised, then continued into the demon cave. In the stone tablet array of the front courtyard stood many newly initiated little demons and devils, diligently meditating in cultivation.

Supervising them was a demon clan member covered in black armor, with red pupils and a face carved like a knife, currently holding a large blade with an expression cold as ice.

"Shang Qiu⁴, where is the Demon Lord? I brought something good that I urgently need to show her!" The crow said excitedly.

The demon clan member didn't speak, just shook his head expressionlessly.

"Can't beat a response out of you with a stick." The crow cursed colorfully, then lifted her robes and leaped over the rolling lava to fly into the great hall.

She didn't see anyone along the way, and finally snapped her fingers and muttered: "I knew she'd be there."

She skipped to the garden behind the hall, grabbed two little demons guarding the door, and asked: "Is the Demon Lord in the greenhouse again?"

"Naturally. The Right Envoy is also with her, but today is the final deadline for submitting tears." The little demon pulled the crow aside and asked quietly, "Have you collected enough? If the tears you submit aren't sufficient, you'll have to cry in person!"

"Don't worry, I've had enough for a long time." The crow patted the little demon's shoulder. "Today is the Qingming Festival⁵—it's not peaceful. You keep good watch."

After saying this, she continued hopping toward the greenhouse that emitted a soft glow, holding her breath as she knocked on the door.

The door creaked open, revealing a girl in a white-purple silk dress. The girl's hair was styled in a bird-tail bun with two strands of black hair hanging from the top, and she had a beautiful face.

"Shh." The girl spoke with an extremely clear and pleasant voice. "What are you doing here? The Demon Lord finally fell asleep—be careful not to wake her."

"Hmph! You're allowed to accompany the Demon Lord but I'm not? I won't have it!" The crow stuck out her tongue at her, then twisted her body and bent down to squeeze in. "Demon Lord! Demon Lord!"

"You damned crow." The girl quickly closed the door. "Keep it down!"

"Stinking magpie, don't stop me! I brought back something good on this trip—I can't delay!"

As the two were arguing, a cool breeze suddenly came from behind them. They immediately fell silent, their eyes darting about as they smiled awkwardly and shuffled their feet, looking toward the woman who had opened her eyes in the distance.

Those phoenix eyes seemed to hide deep seas within them, containing myriad emotions that couldn't be discerned. Her lips were red as fresh blood, and when they parted slightly, the two immediately lowered their heads and knelt, eyes on nose, nose on heart.

"What's all the noise about?" The woman spoke, then supported herself on the edge of the beauty couch to sit up, thousands of soft strands cascading like seaweed, covering her lotus-white shoulders.

Night had fallen, and the luminous pearls' light had dimmed, but even in such dim lighting, her skin was still pale as paper, like a demon or spirit.

"Reporting to the Demon Lord, this subordinate saw that you've been facing that pot of flowers daily recently, looking quite haggard. But we have few physicians in the Demon Realm, so I went outside and kidnapped a medical immortal to examine your condition."

"Kidnapped a medical immortal." The woman suddenly stood up, instantly half-crouching before the crow, her slender index finger hooking under her chin to lift her face.

"Didn't this lord say not to harm others at will?"

"You did, you did." The crow trembled all over. "But this subordinate was truly worried about the Demon Lord. That, that pot of flowers has been growing for decades without blooming, and you..."

The woman lowered her eyelids, her lips sharp at the corners, her finger applying slight pressure.

"Han Ya⁶! You! Look how you've angered the Demon Lord!" The girl in the silk dress beside them quickly pushed her companion. "The Demon Lord forbade us from causing trouble outside. Even if you're worried about the Demon Lord, you, you can't disobey orders!"

The woman glanced at her lightly, and she immediately lowered her head, not daring to say more.

But the hand pinching her chin loosened, and she stood up and put on her clothes: "Release her."

"Yes." Han Ya pouted. "This person is some young master of the Jiang family. This subordinate only heard that her medical skills were extraordinary, which is why..."

"Wait." The woman frowned and turned around. "Who?"

"Jiang, Jiang family, Jiang Li." Han Ya hid behind the girl in the silk dress and said quietly.

"Bring her out." The woman said.

So Han Ya pulled out a black crow feather from her hair, and with a bang, an orange-yellow dressed beauty tumbled to the ground with a thud, clutching her waist and crying out delicately.

That person was indeed Jiang Li. She was still wearing banquet attire, her peach cheeks flushed as she began to accuse: "What demon dares to take advantage of me while I was unconscious from testing medicine! Do you know who I am? Be careful that I..."

"Medical Immortal Jiang." The woman spoke. She had already dressed, her red and black dress making her figure appear tall and elegant. Every inch of exposed snow-white skin added several points of allure. She wore many bells and precious beads that jingled with her movements. On her fingertip was a black ring, at her chest was a small sword used as a pendant, and a snow-white jade pendant.

Jiang Li stared at that jade pendant and stopped speaking, finally saying in shock: "Ning, Ning Fuyi?"

"It really is you!" Jiang Li immediately got up from the ground, lifting her skirt to approach. "After decades of not seeing you, I thought you were dead!"

She was about to reach out and touch Ning Fuyi, but Ning Fuyi instinctively stepped back to avoid her.

Jiang Li's hand stopped awkwardly in mid-air. She smiled and rubbed her palms together: "Indeed, it's been many years. You've become more and more like the Divine Venerable."

"By the way, where is the Divine Venerable?" she asked urgently.

If there had been some joy at seeing an old friend just now, that joy instantly vanished without a trace. Ning Fuyi lowered her slender eyelashes and turned to look at a lush gardenia flower placed on the stone table.

"It bloomed!" Jiang Li was about to rejoice, but seeing Ning Fuyi's expression dark as ink, she closed her mouth.

"It bloomed. The flower has been blooming for half a month." Ning Fuyi said indifferently. She reached out to touch that pure white flower, and upon her touch, the flower shyly closed into a bud.

"But it's not Chu Qingqiu—it's just a gardenia flower." Ning Fuyi smiled mockingly. "I fed it with tears day and night. When mine weren't enough, I stole others', but it had no effect whatsoever."

Jiang Li also bit her lip: "Is there really no other way?"

"Perhaps there is, but I don't dare hope anymore. Too much hope leads to despair." Ning Fuyi smiled. She withdrew her hand from the petals. "This flower contains only one soul⁷. The other two souls and seven earthly spirits⁸ are nowhere to be found."

"I've sent Jiuying to Penglai to steal Penglai's Soul-Chasing Candle⁹. As for whether those remaining two souls and seven spirits exist in this world, I can only leave it to fate."

Jiang Li watched her speak lightly while her eyes were slightly red, and opened her mouth to offer some words of comfort. But just then the door burst open, and something crashed in like a meteorite, nearly knocking everyone present away.

Jiang Li was struck at the waist and nearly fainted. Ning Fuyi's two subordinates instantly transformed into their original forms, bird feathers flying everywhere.

Ning Fuyi quickly grabbed the glass cup and held it to her chest, flashing to a distant spot to avoid disaster.

"Ning Fuyi! Look what I brought back!" A qilin¹⁰ and white tiger who had crashed head-first to the ground both bounced up, one shouting excitedly, the other roaring with excitement.

The tears in Ning Fuyi's eyes were scared back by the two divine beasts. She silently wiped away the teardrops and frowned as she looked over: "What?"

"The Soul-Chasing Candle, naturally!" Jiuying was so excited she forgot to transform back into human form. With a stomp of her hoof, she leaped onto the stone table and used her mouth to place what looked like an ordinary candle on the table.

"Hey, Medical Immortal Jiang, long time no see!" Jiuying smiled and greeted Jiang Li, who had fallen under the table and was seeing stars, then cast a spell to light the candle flame.

"Petals, petals!" Jiuying pawed at Ning Fuyi with her beast hooves. Ning Fuyi said nothing and quickly plucked a petal from the gardenia to hand to her.

The flower cried out in pain, quickly opened its stamen, and bit down on Ning Fuyi's hand.

"Good girl." Ning Fuyi seemed accustomed to this, stroking the gardenia's stamen, causing the flower to tremble and droop softly.

As soon as the pendant touched the flame, the originally normal flame turned white. At first it flickered, then suddenly steadied and bent toward one direction.

"Baili Shiqi¹¹ told me that as long as this candle flame changes, it proves this person's soul is still there and hasn't scattered. You just need to follow the direction the candle flame points to find where the soul is!" Jiuying shook her head and swayed her tail as she spoke.

After hearing what she said, Ning Fuyi suddenly went weak and nearly fell. Fortunately, Han Ya transformed back into human form and steadied her.

"Demon Lord, what's wrong with you?" Han Ya asked worriedly.

"It's nothing." Ning Fuyi smiled for the first time in a long while. She bent over covering her heart, her breathing slightly trembling.

"Han Ya, Xi Que¹², pack our things. I'm going to find her right now!"

Footnotes:

¹ **Four realms** (四界): Refers to the mortal realm, immortal realm, demon realm, and possibly the ghost/underworld realm in this cultivation world.

² **Terror Hall** (懔畏堂): A made-up organization name meaning "Hall of Fear and Dread."

³ **Zhaoyao Conference** (招摇大会): A major gathering mentioned earlier in the story, likely a prestigious cultivation world event.

⁴ **Shang Qiu** (商仇): A character's name meaning "Commercial Vengeance" or "Trading Enmity."

⁵ **Qingming Festival** (清明): Also known as Tomb Sweeping Day, a traditional Chinese festival for honoring deceased ancestors.

⁶ **Han Ya** (寒鸦): Means "Cold Crow," the name of the crow-transformed subordinate.

⁷ **One soul** (一魂): In Chinese mythology, humans have three souls (三魂) and seven earthly spirits (七魄).

⁸ **Seven earthly spirits** (七魄): The seven corporeal souls that govern bodily functions in Chinese spiritual beliefs.

⁹ **Soul-Chasing Candle** (追魂烛): A magical artifact that can track souls and determine if they still exist.

¹⁰ **Qilin** (麒麟): A mythical Chinese creature, often called a Chinese unicorn, considered highly auspicious.

¹¹ **Baili Shiqi** (百里拾七): A character's name meaning "Hundred Li Seventeen" (Li is a Chinese unit of distance).

¹² **Xi Que** (喜鹊): Means "Magpie," the name of the other bird-transformed subordinate.